

Study sheet — Sukkot

Leviticus 22:26–23:44 · Haftarah Zechariah 14:1–21 · Gospel Luke 2:1–20 · Arie Alberts

§0 Observation round

0.1 Blind observation

The reading opens not at the booth but at God's holy Name and "My feasts" (22:32–23:2): the moadim are God's appointed times, not human traditions. Leviticus 23 begins with the sabbath (23:3) — the rhythm of stopping and receiving — and then runs through the whole year to Sukkot, which comes after Yom Kippur: "rejoice before the LORD seven days" (23:40). The reason is given: "that your generations may know that I made them dwell in booths" (23:43). It is at once a harvest feast (asif) and a memorial of the wilderness. Zechariah 14 widens the picture: war over Jerusalem, God intervenes, "the LORD shall be king over all the earth" (14:9), living waters, and the nations come year after year to keep Sukkot (14:16). Luke 2: the King comes small and vulnerable, no room, shepherds, great joy.

0.2 The four axes as an open question

Does the weight fall on what God is and does (Source: carries, keeps, comes to dwell), on the movement through time (Trajectory: wilderness → harvest → Yom Kippur → Sukkot → kingship → incarnation), on the wholeness of inner/outer (Coherence: receiving dependence ↔ the booth as a visible witness, the nations), or on the response (Will: coming out of the house, practising joy)?

0.3 The centre of gravity read off

● Load-bearing are **Source** and **Trajectory**: God carries and keeps (the booth = dependence; "in the shade"), and the feast points forward — to God's kingship over the nations and to the God who truly comes to dwell in the Messiah. Centre of gravity: coming out of the fixed house to learn that He carries us — and that dwelling-under-His-shade becomes a visible witness reaching to the nations.

0.4 Framing test

● Guarded. The weekly reflex lands on "receiving / You carry me"; here that is grounded (the booth is dependence; Onkelos: dwelling "in the shade"), but Trajectory (kingship, incarnation) and the Coherence line (the booth outward, the nations coming) keep it away from private surrender. Two guards, set by the author himself: Luke 2 not as proof of a birth date, and John 1:14 ("tabernacling") not as an etymological trick — confessional horizon, not a closing code.

§1 The thread

What truly carries us? Not our structure, but the God who carried through the wilderness and made them dwell "in the shade." Coming out of the fixed house teaches receiving; and precisely

that fragile, obedient booth becomes a silent witness — that God wants to dwell with His people, and that His kingship reaches to the nations.

§2 Peshat per block

Block	What it says (peshat)	Keyword / contrast	Open question
Lev. 22:26–33	Offering rules; “do not profane My Name”; “I am the LORD who sanctifies you”.	sanctify · My Name	Why the sanctifying first, then the feasts?
Lev. 23:1–3	First the sabbath: six days work, the seventh rest.	sabbath · rest	What does it mean that the sabbath comes first?
Lev. 23:4–36	The moadim through the year up to Sukkot; “My feasts”.	moadim · appointed time	Why does Sukkot come after Yom Kippur?
Lev. 23:39–44	Four kinds of foliage; seven days of joy; dwelling in booths “that generations may know”.	joy · remember (23:43)	Were those booths human-made or God’s clouds?
Zech. 14:1–9	War over Jerusalem; God intervenes; “the LORD king over all the earth”.	judgment → kingship	How does Sukkot become a world-perspective?
Zech. 14:8,16–17	Living waters from Jerusalem; the nations come year after year to keep Sukkot; else no rain.	source · the nations	Who may claim the gift apart from the Giver?
Zech. 14:20–21	“Holiness to the LORD” down to the horses’ bells and the cooking pots.	holy ↔ ordinary	Where does the holy stop and the ordinary begin?
Luke 2:1–20	Augustus’ census; no room; child in	power → vulnerability	Who is truly King?

Block	What it says (peshat)	Keyword / contrast	Open question
	swaddling and a manger; shepherds; great joy; peace on earth.		

§3 Two load-bearing axes

Axis	Text anchors	Diagnosis	Open anomaly
Source	Lev. 23:43 · Zech. 14:8 · Luke 2:11	Load-bearing. God carries, keeps and comes to dwell; what we receive (breath, harvest, salvation) is gift.	Why does He teach it precisely through vulnerability?
Trajectory	Lev. 23:4–44 (year) · Yom Kippur → Sukkot · Zech. 14:9 · Luke 2	Load-bearing, second pole. The feast-year and salvation history run out to kingship and incarnation.	Pointer or own core?
Coherence	Lev. 23:42 (visible dwelling) · Zech. 14:16 (nations) · John 1:14	Hinge. Inner (receiving dependence) ↔ outer (the booth as witness, the nations coming).	Does “witnessing” become achievement or stay silent?
Will	Lev. 23:40 (rejoice) · coming out of the house	Response, not source: come out of the fixed house, practise joy, receive.	Where is “commanding joy” forced?

§4 Sources round

Van de Giessen does not cover Leviticus (does cover Genesis 1–25 and Deut. 18–34); the witnesses were verified via Sefaria.

● **The dispute over the booths (Sukkah 11b).** “I made the children of Israel dwell in sukkot” (23:43): R. Eliezer — these were the clouds of glory (ananei kavod); R. Akiva — they made real booths. Rashi (and Ramban) follow the clouds; Rashbam and Ibn Ezra hold the

peshat of real booths. The two poles — frail human work (vulnerability) and God’s covering (keeping) — together carry exactly the doubleness of this feast.

● **Onkelos on 23:43.** He translates: I made them dwell “in the shade of the clouds.” That anchors the title “dwelling in His shade” directly in the earliest translation-reading.

● **Zohar (Emor).** The sukkah is called “the shade of faith” (tzila di-mehimnuta): when one sits in it, the Shekhinah spreads her wings over him, and the patriarchs (the ushpizin) are guests. Illustrative, not load-bearing.

● **Harvest feast (asif; Ex. 23:16).** Sukkot is originally the autumn ingathering feast; 23:43 uniquely ties that harvest to the exodus/wilderness — labour and gift in one feast.

● **Water libation (nisuch ha-mayim)** as background to Zechariah’s living waters: historically known, not developed here (open verification point).

Revision gate. Did the round shift the centre? Confirming: Onkelos’ “shade” and the dispute give the doubleness (frail + kept) its peshat ground, and hold the centre on Source+Trajectory without letting the reflex become flat surrender.

§5 Direction test as horizon

● Confessional. Luke 2 shows the King who comes small and vulnerable to be received — the God who comes to dwell with His people (cf. Zech. 14: the LORD King, the nations coming). And John 1:14 (“the Word... dwelt / tabernacled among us”) pictures God’s nearness. ● Guarded: Luke 2 does not fix a birth date on Sukkot, and John 1:14 is no etymological key — both are confessional horizon, not peshat-setter.

§6 Status table

Claim	Status
The moadim are God’s appointed times; time belongs to God (22:32–23:2)	● load-bearing
The booth = dependence; joy comes after atonement (23:40,43)	● load-bearing
Onkelos: dwelling “in the shade of the clouds” (23:43) — anchors the title	● load-bearing (verified)
Dispute booths/clouds (Sukkah 11b): frail human work and God’s keeping, both	● / ● pre-peshat
Zohar: the sukkah as “shade of faith” + ushpizin	● suggestive (mystical)
Zechariah: kingship over the nations; the nations keep Sukkot (14:9,16)	● load-bearing
Reflex-landing on flat surrender; “witnessing” as achievement	● guardrail

Claim	Status
Luke 2 / John 1:14: God comes to dwell — confessional, no birth date, no etymological trick	☒ confessional
Water libation as background to Zech. 14:8	☐ open verification point

§7 Podcast rendering

One physical image: the booth standing beside the house, visible to whoever drives past — and withering through the week. You set it up green, you enjoy it, and the leaves fall; yet the joy remains, because it did not hang on the foliage but on the Giver. And the second half: when the conversation is over, the booth itself becomes the witness — silent, but visible: God wants to dwell with us.

§8 Source accountability

Dispute booths/clouds (Sukkah 11b; Rashi/Ramban vs. Rashbam/Ibn Ezra), Onkelos on 23:43 (“in the shade”), Zohar Emor (tzila di-mehimnuta) — verified via Sefaria. Harvest feast/asif (Ex. 23:16). Van de Giessen not available for Leviticus. Water libation: open verification point. Name: Yeshua. Author: Arie Alberts.